CURATING HISTORY

2.5

San Jacinto Museum of History La Porte, Texas

A museum with a unique location, the San Jacinto is housed in the base of the San Jacinto Monument. It was established as a steward of history to honor those who fought in the Texas War for Independence from Mexico and showcase the history of Texas and the Spanish Southwest. Visitors can view art and artifacts from the Spanish conquest, Spanish colonial life, the Mexican Revolution, the colonization of Mexican Texas, early Texas statehood, and the Civil War. What can you infer about the relationship between Mexico and Texas by examining the artifacts below?



Soldiers sharpened the curve on the top of the blade, called a clip point, to inflict a more serious wound as the knife was pulled out.

Texas Army Bowie Knife

Alamo hero and knife-fighter Jim Bowie knew what he wanted in a knife. He worked with blacksmiths to create knives like this one that had curved blades and cross-guards to protect hands. It was a handy weapon, useful for hunting, digging, or cutting down trees, as well as in hand-to-hand combat.

Mexican Badge

This heavy brass badge, likely worn by a soldier in the Mexican Army, features the Mexican military insignia, an eagle perched on a cactus plant. The streamer beneath the eagle's talons reads: "LIBERTAD MEXICANA" (Mexican freedom).

Santa Anna's Knee Buckle

In the late 1700s, many men wore knee buckles to secure their short pants, or breeches, at the knee. This buckle has 22 square diamonds, a handsome design, and an impressive history. Santa Anna gave this buckle to Sam Houston after Houston defeated him in the Battle of San Jacinto. Historians agree Santa Anna was a strong leader with a dynamic personality, but he also lacked principles and loved military glory, which often led Mexico down the wrong path.



Notice this pistol's unusual octagon-shaped barrel.

Texas Army Percussion Pistol

This wood and brass pistol belonged to Euclid M. Cox, who used it during the 1838 Battle Creek Massacre. A group of 25 Texan surveyors, who were studying the land for its settlement potential, encountered 300 members of the Kickapoo tribe. After failing to heed a warning to leave, the Texans were ambushed. Only seven survived.

Texas Army Military Sword Belt

A sword belt like this one, made of gold braid and maroon leather, was an important part of a soldier's uniform. This one belonged to Thomas Jefferson Chambers of the Texas Army. The belt's decorative round buckle is trimmed with leaves and berries and has a silver, five-pointed star set in the center. The two chains attached to the belt end in hooks that Chambers would have fastened to his sword's scabbard, or sheath.

Do you think this sword belt would have been a practical accessory? Why or why not?